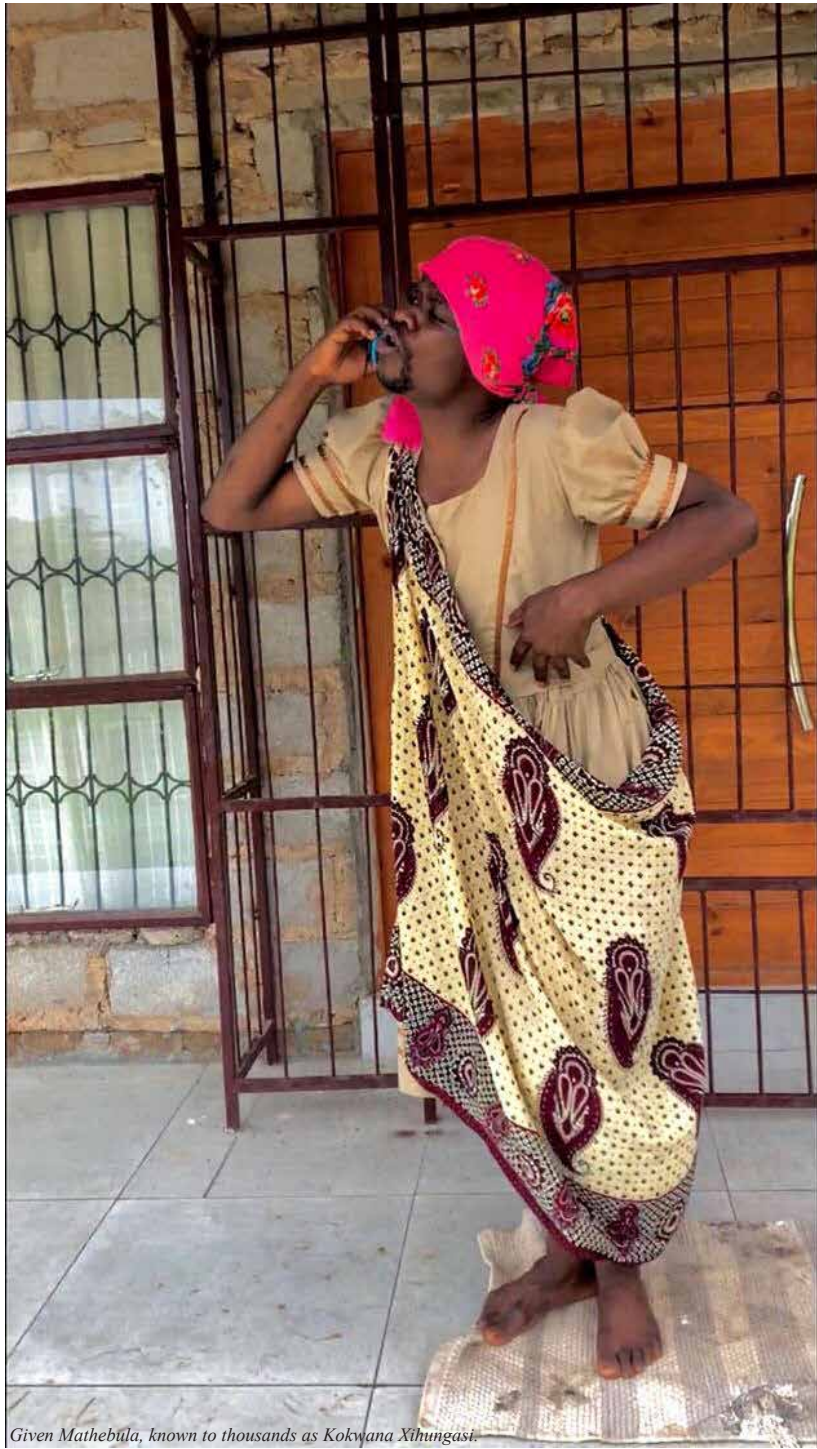


Friday, 27 February 2026

Bushbuckridge's Comedy Star: Kokwana Xihungasi



Bushbuckridge has a new star making waves—Given Mathebula, known to thousands as Kokwana Xihungasi, is bringing laughter to social media with his Xitsonga comedy content.

With 20,000 Facebook followers and 29,500 TikTok fans, Kokwana Xihungasi has quickly become a household name in our community.

But his journey began long before the likes and follows. Given started performing comedy in primary school, inspired by the daily life and unique voice of his late mother, Xihungasi.

"My mom was my hero. I always enjoyed when she shouted at me because I liked her voice," he shares.

His content honours her memory, capturing the humour in her everyday actions and turning it into laughter for thousands online.

Kokwana Xihungasi officially

launched his comedy in September 2025, and by January 2026, he started gaining significant attention. "First of all, I'd like to thank God for everything. If it wasn't for Him, I wouldn't be here. I also want to thank my sister, Lerato Stella Mathebula, for supporting my content," Given says.

Based in Acornhoek Timbavati, near Dynamic Church, Given is not just a comedian—he's also a music producer under the name Carter Deowl. His dream is bigger than laughter; he wants to make people happy across South Africa and beyond, raising the Bushbuckridge flag high.

As his content continues to touch lives, one thing is clear: Kokwana Xihungasi is proof that local talent, driven by passion and love, can inspire a global audience.

From heartfelt memories of his mother to thousands of fans laughing at his skits, Given Mathebula is on a journey that reminds us all—laughter truly knows no borders.



CRIME Police Seize Illegal Guns in Bushbuckridge



COMMUNITY Schools Drug Crackdown in BBR



SPORTS Masoganeng Hold Real Rangers



Given Mathebula, known to thousands as Kokwana Xihungasi.



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SPIRITUAL REBIRTH

Israel Renews Covenant After Crossing Jordan

Gilgal – Following Israel’s miraculous crossing of the River Jordan, fear spread among the surrounding nations as reports of the Lord’s intervention reached the kings of the Amorites west of the river and the Canaanite rulers along the coast. Scripture records that their hearts “melted in fear” and they no longer had the courage to face the Israelites.

At this pivotal moment, the Lord instructed Joshua to carry out a significant act of obedience. He was commanded to circumcise the Israelite men, as the new generation born during the forty years in the wilderness had not received the covenant sign. The previous generation, who had left Egypt, had died during the desert journey

because of their disobedience.

Joshua complied, performing the circumcision at a place later associated with this act of renewal. The procedure symbolised the restoration of the covenant between God and His people before they advanced further into the Promised Land.

The passage highlights a transition: the end of wilderness wandering and the beginning of conquest. Before engaging in battle, Israel was first called to spiritual consecration. The moment underscored that their strength would not come from numbers or weapons, but from obedience and faithfulness to God.

Jobs and Growth Pact Signed



The Memorandum of Understanding (MoU), signed at the university’s campus.

A major partnership aimed at creating jobs and growing the economy was signed today, 25 February, between the Mpumalanga Provincial Government and the University of Mpumalanga.

The Memorandum of Understanding (MoU), signed at the university’s campus in Tlokoma, focuses on tackling unemployment, supporting small farmers, growing local businesses and creating real opportunities for ordinary people across the province.

Premier Mandla Ndlovu said the agreement is about action, not speeches. The goal is to turn education, farming and business into practical job opportunities that improve daily life for communities.

A key focus of the partnership is agriculture, which remains one of Mpumalanga’s strongest economic sectors. The plan includes expanding farming projects, improving access to markets, and supporting small-scale and emerging farmers so they can earn a stable income from their produce.

One of the major developments linked to the agreement is the growth of a large fresh produce market, which will allow farmers to sell their crops more easily and access bigger local and international markets. This is expected to create jobs in farming, transport, trading, packaging

and processing.

The MoU also introduces a hybrid rice farming project, which will be piloted in the province. This project is expected to create large-scale employment over time and open doors for young people, small farmers and local entrepreneurs to enter commercial agriculture.

For ordinary residents, the impact of the agreement is expected to be felt in everyday life:

- Better access to markets for local produce
- More job opportunities in farming and agri-business
- Support for small and emerging farmers
- Growth of local small businesses (SMMEs)
- Training and skills development for young people

- Better access to markets for local produce

The partnership also connects the university directly to communities, allowing students and researchers to work on real projects that solve real problems, instead of knowledge staying only in lecture halls.

The MoU will run for five years, with the option to be renewed, and will be guided by a joint steering committee to ensure projects are implemented and monitored properly.

For many families across Mpumalanga, today’s signing represents more than a formal agreement — it signals a serious effort to turn education, land and opportunity into jobs, income and a better future.



Editor’s Note

This week, we celebrate INITIATIVES

This week, we celebrate initiatives that bring real opportunities — from creating jobs to supporting farmers and small businesses. Stories like these show what’s possible when government, education, and communities work together.

Bushbuckridge News continues to share the voices, achievements, and creativity of our people. Keep reading, stay inspired, and let’s seize the opportunities around us to build a stronger, brighter future together.

— Ophelia Mnisi

CRIME
Police Seize
Illegal Guns in
Bushbuckridge



Illegal firearms and ammunition were seized during a police operation in the Ehlanzeni District, Mpumalanga, as part of Operation Shanela.

The intelligence-driven operation, conducted between 23 and 24 February 2026, involved a multidisciplinary police team working alongside local Farm Watch structures in Calcutta, Acornhoek and Bushbuckridge. Officers carried out stop-and-searches, patrols, and compliance inspections at hotspots including Saselani and Dwarsloop.

During the operation, two men were arrested for possession of unlicensed firearms and ammunition. A 30-year-old suspect, Lucas Khosa, and 25-year-old Ripfumelo Kubayi were linked to firearms recovered by police, including multiple 9mm pistols and magazines. One of the seized firearms is suspected to be state-issued.

Court updates:

Ripfumelo Kubayi (25) was granted R1 000 bail by the Acornhoek Magistrate’s Court and is expected back in court on 17 March. Meanwhile, Lucas Khosa (30) remains in custody after being remanded and will appear before the Bushbuckridge Magistrate’s Court on 2 March for a formal bail application.

Acting Provincial Commissioner of the South African Police Service in Mpumalanga, Major General (Dr) Zeph Mkhwanazi, commended officers for their swift response and effective coordination. He emphasised that intelligence-led operations and cooperation with community structures such as farm patrols are vital to removing illegal firearms and ensuring safer communities.

“These coordinated efforts strengthen cohesion among law enforcement partners and significantly contribute to proactive policing,” said Mkhwanazi.

The case continues.

Schools Drug Crackdown in BBR

The South African Police Service (SAPS), working in partnership with the Department of Correctional Services and private security companies, carried out successful search and seizure operations on 18 and 19 February 2026 in the Bushbuckridge area.

The coordinated, intelligence-driven operation targeted a number of randomly selected schools, including Hobo, Tamajane, Masana, Letshele, Sekhukhusa and Dutau, within the Bushbuckridge Local Municipality.

The operation formed part of SAPS’s ongoing efforts to combat drugs and other illicit activities in and around schools, with a focus on protecting learners and restoring safety within learning environments.

During the raids, some learners found in possession of dagga cooperated with law enforcement officials, leading police to the premises of suspected suppliers. Most of the dagga shown in circulated images was seized directly from these suppliers, who



have since been arrested. Police indicated that the operation was not only aimed at removing drugs from schools, but at dismantling the supply networks that target learners and operate within local communities.

The raids reflect a broader strategy by SAPS to disrupt criminal syndicates, strengthen school safety, and prevent young people from being drawn into drug-related activities.

Authorities have urged parents, educators and community members to work closely with law enforcement by reporting drug activity, supporting prevention programmes, and helping to create safer environments for children.

The operation marks a significant step in strengthening security in schools and reinforcing the message that criminal activity targeting learners will be met with decisive law enforcement action.

Skukuza: World’s Most Beautiful Airport

There is something truly special about landing inside the wilderness — and now the world is taking notice.

Skukuza Airport, nestled deep within the heart of the Kruger National Park, has been named the most beautiful airport in the world by Forbes — a title that feels not just deserved, but inevitable.

This is no ordinary airport terminal. With its distinctive thatched roof, warm wooden finishes, sweeping bushveld views and a striking life-sized rhino replica, Skukuza Airport feels less like a transport hub and more like the opening scene of a safari adventure. From the moment passengers step inside, the experience is immersive, calm and unmistakably African — a seamless blend of luxury and wilderness.

Forbes captured the essence of the airport perfectly, describing it as a space that “ditches the classic airport look and embraces a luxury spa vibe instead”. Designed to feel warm, welcoming and tranquil, it offers the ideal farewell after days — or even weeks — spent surrounded by wildlife, and the perfect welcome for those just beginning their journey into the bush.

Skukuza Airport operates as a small but vital gateway within the park. Airlink offers direct flights from Johannesburg, Durban and Cape Town, making access to the Kruger easier than ever before. While charter aircraft also operate from the airport, Airlink remains the only commercial airline servicing this unique destination.

The airport is located close to Skukuza Main Camp — the administrative headquarters of the Kruger National Park —

and lies near the adjoining Sabi Sand Conservancy, placing visitors within immediate reach of some of South Africa’s most renowned wildlife areas.

Skukuza Airport’s history stretches back to 1959, but it was reopened just over a decade ago as part of a strategic move to improve access to the Kruger. The reopening aimed to reduce the long road journey from Nelspruit into the park, making travel safer, faster and more convenient for both local and international visitors.

Today, the airport stands as a successful public-private partnership between SANParks and Skukuza Airport Management Company, jointly owned by Lion Sands and Airlink — a collaboration that has transformed a small regional airport into a globally recognised landmark.

More than just a transport facility, Skukuza Airport has become a symbol of how infrastructure can harmonise with nature, rather than compete with it. Its global recognition is not only a win for tourism, but a proud moment for South Africa and for Mpumalanga in particular.

In a world of glass terminals and concrete runways, Skukuza stands apart — a beautiful gateway to the wild, and now officially, the most beautiful airport on Earth.





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VA NA NA RITO

NAWU WA MATIKHOMELO LAMANENE NA KU PALUXIWA KA KU TSAKELA KA SWIRHO SWA HUVO YA RIXAKA NA SWIRHO SWA HUVO SWA NKARHI HINKWAWO

Xikombelo xa Swibumabumelo Leswi Tsariweke

Komiti ya Nhlangelano ya swa Matikhomelo Lamanene na ku Tsakela ka Swirho yi rhamba vatekaxiave na vanhu lava nga na ku tsakela ku yisa swibumabumelo leswi tsariweke hi xikongomelo xo cinciwa loku nga va ka kona ka Nawu wa Matikhomelo Lamanene na ku Paluxiwa ka ku Tsakela ka Swirho swa Huvo ya Rixaka na Swirho swa Huvo swa Nkarhi Hinkwawo.

Swibumabumelo leswi tsariweke swi fanele ku amukeriwa ku nga se hundza 17:00 hi ti 31 Nyenyankulu 2026, naswona swi fanele ku imeyileriwa eka registrar@parliament.gov.za

Nawu wa Matikhomelo Lamanene na ku Paluxiwa ka ku Tsakela ka Swirho wa sweswi wa kumeka eka <https://www.parliament.gov.za/code-conduct>

Xi humesiwile hi Muchaviseki L S Makhubela, Xirho xa Palamende na Muchaviseki JHB Britz, Xirho xa Palamende
Vatshamaxitulu Lava fambisaka swin’we va Komiti ya Nhlangelano ya swa Matikhomelo Lamanene na ku Tsakela ka Swirho

Palamende – Ku landzelerisa ku tiyimisela ka hina eka vanhu – Ku endla vumundzuku bya n’wina byi tirha ku antswa

Education Corruption Case Moves to Court



A sweeping corruption case involving the Mpumalanga Department of Education has entered a critical phase, with dozens of accused appearing before the Nelspruit Magistrate's Court over two days as bail proceedings unfold in one of the province's largest education-related fraud matters.

The case stems from a R113 million corruption investigation led by the Directorate for Priority Crime Investigation (Hawks), targeting alleged collusion between departmental officials and private service providers. Investigators allege that handpicked companies were unlawfully appointed to carry out school repairs at inflated prices, with payments made for work that was either partially completed or never performed.

First Court Appearance – 23 February 2026

On Monday, 23 February, 33 accused appeared before court in connection with charges of fraud, theft, money laundering, corruption and contraventions of the Public Finance Management Act.

Due to medical considerations, the court prioritised bail applications for five accused. A wheelchair-bound suspect was granted bail of R5,000. Two government officials and one service provider were granted bail of R50,000 each, while one accused who is breastfeeding was also considered for bail set at R50,000.

Those granted bail were ordered to surrender all travel documents to the investigating officer and may not leave the country without formal court permission. They are expected to return to court on 26 March 2026.

The remaining accused were remanded in custody, with the court confirming that they would appear the following day for bail applications. They were joined by three additional suspects who were arrested on 23 February, bringing the total number of accused before the court to 33.

Among the high-profile individuals granted bail on medical grounds were:

- Absolom Thela, former acting Chief Financial Officer of the Department of Education
- Palesa Thela, daughter of Absolom Thela

- Nono Maribe, former senior departmental official
- Ruth Khoza, a private service provider

Each was granted bail of R50,000, subject to strict conditions and travel restrictions.

Bail Proceedings Continue – 24 February 2026

Bail applications continued on Tuesday, 24 February, with more than 30 accused processed in groups due to the scale of the case. Presiding officer Patrick Morris elected to hear the applications in batches of 10.

As the first group entered Court C, several accused attempted to shield their faces from the media. Magistrate Morris reprimanded the accused, ordering them to sit upright and uncover their faces, emphasising the seriousness of the proceedings and the authority of the court.

The first accused to apply for bail on Tuesday was Jabulani Rolland Nkosi (52). An affidavit presented to the court revealed that Nkosi is a director in the Mpumalanga Department of Health and a former Acting Head of Department for the Department of Education. His career history also includes management experience at the Kruger National Park.

In his affidavit, Nkosi maintained his innocence and stated his intention to clear his name.

"I submit to the honourable court that I possess a travel document which I use to visit my in-laws in eSwatini. I am married with children, and my wife is currently unemployed. I intend to plead not guilty if granted bail, and I shall abide by all conditions imposed by the court," the affidavit read.

Nkosi disclosed ownership of movable and immovable property, including a residence in Sunnyside, Pretoria, valued at R250,000.

Magistrate Morris granted Nkosi bail of R50,000, subject to strict conditions, including:

Surrendering his passport to the investigating officer

Refraining from interfering with state witnesses

Attending all scheduled court appearances

Before the court adjourned for lunch, Whisky Mhlabane, Wellemina Mathe, and Sibongile Sithole Dlamini were also granted bail, with amounts ranging between R20,000 and R50,000.

At the time of publication, several other accused remained in custody, with their bail applications scheduled to continue on Wednesday, 25 February 2026.



The Allegations

The case centres on allegations that internal officials within the Department of Education colluded with external service providers to bypass financial controls and procurement regulations. Investigators allege that companies were unlawfully handpicked to conduct school repairs, with invoices inflated and payments made for work that was either overpriced or not carried out at all.

The alleged scheme is estimated to have cost the state more than R110 million, with irregularities dating back more than five years. The accused group includes nine government officials, multiple service providers and other individuals linked to the network.

Departmental Response

The Mpumalanga Department of Education has confirmed awareness of the Hawks' operation and court proceedings. The department has stated that the matter is now before the courts and is regarded as sub judice, and therefore it will not comment on the merits of the case.

The department reiterated its commitment to ethical governance, transparency and accountability, and maintained a zero-tolerance stance on corruption and maladministration. It further confirmed that it will cooperate fully with law enforcement agencies to ensure due process is followed.

What Lies Ahead

With bail proceedings continuing and further arrests already made, the case is expected to remain before the courts for some time. Investigators have indicated that the operation is ongoing, with additional suspects still being pursued.

All accused who were granted bail are expected to return to court on 26 March 2026, while further bail applications are set to continue in the coming days as the justice system processes one of Mpumalanga's most significant education corruption cases to date.




Ms Makhosazane Christine Masilela
Speaker

SOPA 2026

State of the Province Address

**OFFICIAL OPENING OF THE MPUMALANGA PROVINCIAL LEGISLATURE:
STATE OF THE PROVINCE ADDRESS 2026 – 05 MARCH 2026**

The Speaker of the Mpumalanga Provincial Legislature, Ms Makhosazane Christine Masilela has the pleasure of announcing the Official Opening of the 3rd Session of the 7th Mpumalanga Legislature and the delivery of the State of the Province Address (SOPA) by Premier, Mr Mandla Padney Ndlovu. The event is scheduled to take place as follows:

Date : Thursday, 05 March 2026
Time : 10:00 (Invited guests are expected to be seated by 09:00)
Venue : Riverside Government Complex: Baobab Building, Legislature Chamber

The Proceedings will be live on Legislature's Facebook page and YouTube Channel, Ligwalagwala FM, Ikwekwezi FM, Rise FM, Parliamentary channel 408 and on several Community Radio Stations in the Province.

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Reading Culture Takes Centre Stage



programmes and the promotion of a reading culture across all districts.

He stressed that reading should not be limited to the Foundation Phase, but must become a sustained practice throughout a learner’s entire educational journey. He further called on educators, parents and learners to take collective responsibility in nurturing a lifelong love for books.

World Read Aloud Day once again served as a powerful reminder that when communities read together, they grow together — turning the simple act of reading aloud into a lasting investment in education and development.



Acorns to Oaks Secondary School in the Green Valley Circuit, Bohlabela District, hosted a vibrant World Read Aloud Day celebration on Wednesday, 25 February, bringing together learners, educators and partners in a shared commitment to literacy.

The event was organised by the Department of Education in collaboration with Nal’ibali, Room to Read, and the National Education Collaboration Trust, reflecting a united effort to build a nation of readers and

strengthen reading culture in schools.

The celebration highlighted reading as the foundation of all learning and one of the most powerful tools for social and economic transformation. Speakers emphasised that promoting a culture of reading not only supports academic success, but also empowers learners to participate meaningfully in society.

Book publishers Shuter & Shooter and

Maskew Miller Learning also attended the event, reinforcing the importance of access to quality reading materials in schools.

The keynote address was delivered on behalf of the MEC for Education, Lindi Masina, by the Chief Director for General Education and Training (GET), Elvis Siwela. In his message, he reaffirmed the department’s commitment to literacy development through the strengthening of school libraries, structured reading

R533 Graskop Road.
Opp Mapulaneng DLTC
Bushbuckridge
Co-ordinates: 31°3'59.796" E 24°50'24.3304" S
Tel: 013 065 0983



Private bag x 9308
Bushbuckridge
1280
Email: info@bushbuckridge.gov.za
Website: www.bushbuckridge.gov.za

PUBLIC NOTICE CALLING FOR INSPECTION OF THE VALUATION ROLL AND LODGING OF OBJECTIONS

Notice is hereby given in terms of Section 49(1)(a)(i)(c) of the Local Government: Municipal Rates Act, 2004 (Act No. 6 of 2004), herein referred to as the “Act”, that the valuation roll for the financial years 1 July 2026 to 30 June 2031, is open for public inspection at all municipal offices of the Bushbuckridge Municipality, from 21 February 2026 to 30 April 2026 during office hours. In addition, the Valuation roll is available at the Municipality’s official website: www.bushbuckridge.gov.za

An invitation is hereby made in terms of the Section 49(1)(a)(ii) of the Act that any owner of a property or other. person who so desires can lodge an objection with the municipal manager in respect of any matter reflected in or omitted from the valuation roll within the abovementioned period.

Attention is specifically drawn to the fact that in terms of Section 50(2) of the Act, an objection must be in relation to a specific individual property and not against the valuation roll as such. The form for the lodging of an objection is. obtainable at all offices of the Bushbuckridge Municipality, or at the following websites: www.bushbuckridge.gov.za

The completed form must be returned to one of the addresses listed below before or on 30 April 2026. **No objections received by fax or e-mail will be accepted.**

Enquiries: Ms L Gubudela – 087754 6152/ 072 300 0364

: Ms G Chiloane – 087754 6151/ 072 095 6673

: Mr RN Gazide – 0877546150/ 074 542 8646

Municipal Offices
Bushbuckridge H/O (R533 Graskop Road, opp Mapulaneng DLTC)
Mkhuhlu Office Matikwane Road
Marite Office Main Road (R40)
Maviljan Office Next to Mapulaneng
Dwarsloop Office Opposite Total Garage (R40)
Shatale Office Next to Shatale Post Office
Casteel Office Main Road (R40)
Acornhoek Office Next to Total Garage
Hluvuani Office Main Road to Manyeleti Game Reserve
Thulamahashe Office Next to Home Affairs
Angincort Office
Lillydale Office

Together speeding service delivery

XITIVISO

XIVIKO XA XIKOMBISO XA NHLUVUKISO WA MISAVA HI KU YA HI NAWU WA BUSHBUCKRIDGE WA VULAWURI BYA NDHAWU NA VULAWURI BYA MATIRHISELO YA MISAVA

Mina, Werner Mostert wa feme ya GAP Development Planners, ndzi ngenise xikombelo xa nhluvukiso wa misava ehansi ka nomboro ya ndzavisiso ya T01/2026/GRE hi ku landza Ndzima ya 5, leyi hlayiweke na Xiyenge xa 60 xa Nawu wa Vupulani bya Ndhawu na Vulawuri bya Matirhiselo ya Misava wa Bushbuckridge, 2022. Xikongomelo xa xikombelo i ku simeka doroba ra mabindzu eka Xiphemu xa Vukulu lebyi Saleke bya purasi ra Greenvalley 213-KU leyi vumbiwaka hi kwalomu ka 2 wa ti erven. Ndhawu leyi nga ehansi ka vulawuri yi kumeka endzeni ka vulawuri bya Masipala wa Ndhawu ya Bushbuckridge, kwalomu ka 1km ku suka eka Accornhoek Mall, eka Tikhodixini ta GPS leti landzelaka: 24°35'53.41"S 31°02'51.11"E.

Vuxokoxoko bya xikombelo byi ta etlela ku kamberwa hi nkarhi wa ntolovelo wa hofisi ehofisini ya Mufambisi wa Masipala, Masipala wa Muganga wa Bushbuckridge, leyi kumekaka ethelo ka patu ra R533 Graskop, Ku langutana na Senthara yo Kambela Tilayisense to Chayela ya Mapulaneng (DLTC) kumbe eHofisini ya Masipala ya Muganga ya Bushbuckridge Thulamahashe, Stand 1706, Thulamahashe (ku langutana na Xitediyamu lexintshwa) ku ringana nkarhi wo karhi ya masiku ya 28 ku sukela hi ti 27 Hukuri 2026 ku fikela hi ti 27 Dzivamisoko 2026.

Ku kaneta kumbe vuyimeri mayelana na xikombelo swi fanele ku ngenisiwa eka kumbe ku endlwa hi ku tsala eka Mufambisi wa Masipala eka adrese leyi boxiweke laha henhla kumbe eka Private Bag X9308, Bushbuckridge, 1280.

Munhu un'wana na un'wana loyi a nga kotiki ku hlaya kumbe ku tsala a nga burisana na xirho xihl kumbe xihl xa vatirhi xa hofisi ya Mufambisinkulu: Xiyenge xa Vulawuri bya Matirhiselo ya Misava hi nkarhi wa hofisi naswona mpfuneto wu ta nyikiwa ku tsala swivilelo kumbe mavonelo ya munhu yoloeye.

Vuxokoxoko bya Vuhlanganisi bya Vaendli va swikombelo:
Vito: Vapulani va Nhluvukiso wa GAP
Adirese ya Xiviri: 26 Russell Street, Nelspruit
Nomboro ya Riqingho: (013) 752 7513
Imeyili: admin@gapdevelopments.co.za

NOTICE

NOTIFICATION OF LAND DEVELOPMENT APPLICATION IN TERMS OF THE BUSHBUCKRIDGE SPATIAL PLANNING AND LAND USE MANAGEMENT BY-LAW

I, Werner Mostert of the firm GAP Development Planners, have lodged a land development application under reference number T01/2026/GRE in terms of Chapter 5, read with Section 60 of the Bushbuckridge Spatial Planning and Land Use Management By-Law, 2022. The purpose of the application is to establish a commercial township on a Portion of the Remaining Extent of the farm Greenvalley 213-KU comprising of approximately 2 erven. The subject property is situated within the jurisdiction of the Bushbuckridge Local Municipality, approximately 1km away from the Accornhoek Mall, at the following GPS Coordinates: 24°35'53.41"S 31°02'51.11"E.

Particulars of the application will lie for inspection during normal office hours at the office of the Municipal Manager, Bushbuckridge Local Municipality, situated along the R533 Graskop Road, Opposite Mapulaneng Driving Licensing Testing Centre (DLTC) or at the Bushbuckridge Local Municipality Thulamahashe Office, Stand 1706, Thulamahashe (opposite to new Stadium) for a period of 28 days from 27 February 2026 to 27 March 2026.

Objections to or representation in respect of the application must be lodged with or made in writing to the Municipal Manager at the above-mentioned address or to Private Bag X9308, Bushbuckridge, 1280.

Any person who cannot read or write may consult with any staff member of the office of the Senior Manager: Land Use Management Section during office hours and assistance will be given to transcribe that person's objections or comments.

Applicants Contact Details:
Name: GAP Development Planners
Physical Address: 26 Russell Street, Nelspruit
Phone Number: (013) 752 7513
Email: admin@gapdevelopments.co.za

SAHRC to Investigate Lily Mine Families' Complaint



ActionSA has welcomed the decision by the South African Human Rights Commission (SAHRC) to accept for investigation the complaint lodged by the families of Pretty Nkambule, Solomon Nyirenda, and Yvonne Mnisi regarding the Lily Mine tragedy.

The SAHRC confirmed that the complaint has been assessed and accepted for investigation, a development hailed by Herman Mashaba as an important step toward restoring dignity, accountability, and justice for families who have endured nearly a decade of uncertainty and neglect.

ActionSA criticised the prolonged inaction

by the National Prosecuting Authority and the Department of Mineral Resources, noting that the failure to act decisively has compounded the suffering of victims' families and undermined public confidence in the justice system.

“For ten years, the families of the Lily Mine victims have been denied closure, the return of their loved ones’ remains, and meaningful communication from state institutions,” Mashaba said. “Justice delayed is justice denied. Human dignity does not end with death, and families have a fundamental right to truth, accountability, and closure.”

ActionSA affirmed that it will continue to support the families throughout the investigation and monitor progress closely.

The party stressed that the acceptance of the complaint must lead to concrete action, not further delays, and called for a thorough, independent investigation without undue delay.

The SAHRC investigation now formally begins, marking a significant move toward addressing long-standing human rights concerns related to the Lily Mine tragedy and ensuring accountability within state institutions.



Premier Ndlovu Welcomes Education Officials' Arrests

The Directorate for Priority Crime Investigation (Hawks) carried out arrests of several officials within the Department of Education in Mpumalanga on Sunday, 23 February 2026.

The arrests form part of ongoing efforts to combat corruption and misconduct within government departments. Acting in line with recent pronouncements by President Cyril Ramaphosa during the State of the Nation Address (SONA), the operation reflects a commitment to building a capable, ethical and developmental state.

Premier Mandla Ndlovu welcomed the arrests and encouraged the Department of Education to assess the impact on internal operations, service delivery, and staff morale. He emphasised that the law must take its course and reminded communities that those arrested are presumed innocent until proven guilty in a court of law.

The Premier also underlined the importance of ensuring that the arrests do not disrupt the delivery of critical education services. “The Mpumalanga Provincial Government remains committed to fostering a stable and effective education system that prioritises the well-being and future of our youth,” he said.

The operation highlights the provincial government’s ongoing collaboration with law enforcement agencies to ensure accountability and integrity in public service.

4,000 Ghost Workers Flagged in Govt Payroll

National Treasury has revealed that a nationwide ghost worker audit has identified 4,323 suspicious cases within the government’s payroll system, with a verification process already under way.

According to the department, employees who cannot be physically verified will face withheld salaries and suspension of their employment status, as government moves to clamp down on fraud and irregular payments in the public sector.

Treasury highlighted that compensation of employees consumes nearly one-third of consolidated government spending, making payroll integrity a major priority in efforts to protect public funds and improve service delivery.

As part of broader cost-cutting measures,



the department also confirmed progress in its Early Retirement Programme, which allows qualifying government employees to retire early without financial penalties.

The programme is expected to save R2.6 billion in the current financial year, following the approval of 7,687 applications in its first phase.

To sustain the programme, Treasury has allocated R3.7 billion to departmental baselines for the 2025/26 and 2026/27 financial years, signalling a long-term commitment to reducing the wage bill while stabilising government finances.

The measures form part of government’s wider strategy to clean up public administration, eliminate corruption risks, and ensure that public money is spent on services that directly benefit communities.

Operation Shanela Nets Major Crimes

Operation Shanela II has delivered a major crime breakthrough across Mpumalanga, with hundreds of suspects arrested and significant illegal items confiscated during province-wide operations conducted between 19 and 22 February 2026.

The multi-agency operation was led by the South African Police Service (SAPS) and supported by Traffic Police, law enforcement agencies, the Departments of Home Affairs, Health, Labour, Social Development, Small Business Development and Correctional Services, as well as private security companies and Community Policing Forums (CPFs).

Extensive operations across the province

During the four-day operation:

- 137 premises were searched
- 7 132 people and 2 375 vehicles were searched
- 844 stop-and-search operations were conducted
- 6 specialised tracking operations took place
- 3 556 high-visibility patrols were conducted, including vehicle checkpoints, roadblocks and tracing operations
- 8 hostels, 155 farms, 6 mines and multiple businesses were inspected

Compliance operations led to the closure of unlicensed liquor outlets, inspections of licensed liquor traders, scrap yards, second-hand dealers, firearm dealers, spaza shops, formal businesses, farms and informal traders.

Arrests and serious crimes

Dozens of wanted suspects were arrested

during raids for serious offences including murder, attempted murder, rape, sexual offences, assault GBH, carjacking and illegal possession of firearms.

In total, arrests were made for a wide range of offences, including:

- Illegal possession of firearms and ammunition
- Drug dealing and drug possession
- Illegal liquor trading
- Possession of counterfeit goods
- Illegal cigarettes
- Driving under the influence of alcohol or drugs
- Human trafficking
- Business robbery, armed robbery, burglary and hijacking
- Murder, rape and assault-related crimes

More than 80 illegal immigrants were also arrested during the operation.

Major seizures

- Large quantities of illegal items were confiscated, including:
- Firearms (handguns, rifles and shotguns)
 - Ammunition and explosives
 - Drugs such as dagga, crack cocaine, crystal meth (tik) and nyaope
 - Counterfeit and contraband goods valued at over R1.1 million
 - Alcohol, tobacco products, dangerous weapons, cellphones, cash and vehicles

Home Affairs Visa Scam Exposed



The Special Investigating Unit (SIU) has uncovered a large-scale permit and visa racket within the Department of Home Affairs, estimated to have cost the state more than R180 million.

Acting on a whistleblower tip-off, investigators discovered that four officials — each earning an estimated monthly salary of about R25,000 — allegedly made millions by selling permits and visas to foreign nationals. According to the SIU, the officials used their spouses to launder illicit funds into luxury properties and high-end vehicles.

Acting SIU Head Leonard Lekgetho said the evidence points to serious weaknesses in border and immigration systems, warning that South Africa’s borders have effectively been compromised. He described the department’s operations as being treated “like a marketplace”.

The investigation further revealed that organised syndicates were working with officials responsible for assessing asylum seeker applications. Following a 2024 raid on five refugee reception centres, during which laptops and mobile devices were seized, the SIU found evidence that favourable application outcomes were being sold for between R500 and R3,000.

“The SIU investigation revealed that certain officials turned the permit system into a marketplace,” Lekgetho said. “Their modus operandi was simple: applications were sent via WhatsApp for expedited approval, and once approved, money flowed almost immediately.”

The findings expose deep-rooted corruption within the immigration system and raise serious concerns about national security, border control and the integrity of asylum and permit processes in South Africa.



Masoganeng Hold Real Rangers



Masoganeng United earned a hard-fought 2–2 draw against Real Rangers FC in a Kruger Zone 2 away fixture played on Saturday, 21 February, at Welverdiend's Real Rangers Sports Field.

The visitors started with confidence and opened the scoring through Khutso, who finished well after a neat assist from Puno Malahle.

Real Rangers responded to level the match, and the teams went into half-time locked at 1–1.

The home side took the lead 15 minutes into the second half, putting pressure on

Masoganeng United. However, the visitors showed resilience and character, equalising with 25 minutes left on the clock. Once again, Khutso was on target, this time converting a chance created by Skhuliseni Mokoena.

Masoganeng pushed for a winner in added time and created a clear opportunity, but it went unconverted, leaving the contest finely balanced at the final whistle.

Despite the missed late chance, it was a strong team performance from Masoganeng United, with Khutso deservedly named Player of the Match for his two-goal display against Real Rangers FC.

SAFA Ehlanzeni Hollywoodbets Regional League



			P	W	D	L	GF	GA	GD	Pts
1		Cindy Pirates FC	13	7	4	2	20	13	7	25
2		Masoganeng United FC	12	7	2	3	22	13	9	23
3		Fast XI FC	11	7	0	4	14	10	4	21
4		Eastern Rangers FC	12	5	5	2	26	15	11	20
5		Edinburg United	12	5	5	2	19	9	10	20
6		Ghamalakhe FC	12	5	5	2	15	10	5	20
7		African Vibe FC	12	5	5	2	15	10	5	20
8		Real Rangers FC	11	6	2	3	12	8	4	20
9		Aliwalville Darkies Football Club	10	5	2	3	17	13	4	17
10		Skom Boys FC	11	4	5	2	10	7	3	17
11		Cottendale Invitation FC	12	5	0	7	13	17	-4	15
12		Shining Stars FC	11	4	2	5	13	19	-6	14
13		Zola Power Stars	12	3	4	5	18	17	1	13
14		Apollo Chiefs FC	12	3	4	5	10	12	-2	13
15		Ludlow Young Tigers FC	11	5	2	6	15	21	-6	11
16		Xhombherhobe FC	12	1	4	7	6	23	-17	7
17		Maryke's United	12	1	3	8	10	25	-15	6
18		All Brothers FC	12	0	4	8	7	20	-13	4

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